



Colonial attitudes

The French had little contact with local people, except as servants. Despite living in Indochina, they maintained strictly Western lifestyles and customs—as shown by this photograph of officials and their wives from around 1900.

“We have ... been weak ... but **at no time** have we **suffered** from a **lack of heroes.**”

VIETNAMESE SCHOLAR NGUYEN TRAI, PROCLAMATION OF VICTORY, 1427

Rubber economy

In line with their “civilizing mission,” the French opened schools to educate the children of the Vietnamese elite in French culture, introduced new medical treatments, built roads and railroads, extended irrigation systems, and introduced new crops. However, the main function of the Vietnamese in the French imperial system was to work as exploited laborers on French-owned rubber plantations or in mines. The colonial system paid for itself through customs duties and heavy taxes on salt, alcohol, and opium—the Vietnamese were specifically encouraged to use opium, which was a key source of revenue.

Indochina was not a colony of settlers. After 50 years of colonial rule, the French population of Indochina numbered only 40,000, some 80 percent of whom were soldiers or officials. This minority governed an area with a population of 23 million, who were mostly peasants. Even the small number of educated Vietnamese were left in no doubt of their second-class status. French rule in Vietnam was both oppressive and exploitative. When a crisis came, the French found they had very few allies in Indochina.